

**Title** MD Still marching on(line): How R-FBI Targets Moldova's Elections

08/10/2025

**Summary**

- Between June 19, 2025, and September 25, the Russian influence operation Storm-1516 targeted the Moldovan election with 17 fabricated articles and videos, discrediting the ruling PAS party and the Moldovan democratic system.
- It operated by disseminating fabricated stories, often via fabricated websites. These stories were initially spread by social media accounts affiliated with the operation.
- In the past months, Storm-1516 has dedicated significant resources to influencing the 2025 Moldovan parliamentary elections.
- The content focused on undermining support for Moldova amongst Western audiences, and attacked the ruling PAS party and president Maia Sandu in particular.
- The operation created inauthentic news websites spreading articles through influencers to smear Sandu and PAS's reputation, especially in the eyes of foreign far-right groups.
- The European Commission should impose sanctions on non-sanctioned entities involved in the operation. Their websites and accounts should also be taken down by hosting providers and platforms.

**Incident**

Between June 19, 2025, and September 25, the Russian influence operation Storm-1516, operated by the EU-sanctioned Russian Foundation of Battling Injustice ([R-FBI](#)), targeted the Moldovan election with 17 fabricated articles and videos, discrediting the ruling Party of Action and Solidarity (PAS) and the Moldovan democratic system. The [sanctions](#) include prohibiting others from making funds or economic resources available to R-FBI, which includes hosting their content on social media or servers. The operation was carried out primarily in English and secondarily in Romanian and Russian. The operation utilised at least 13 fabricated websites, 12 of which posed as news outlets, and one impersonating the Moldovan ruling PAS party. The campaign operators also used three existing pro-Russian websites that were seemingly not created by the operation to republish their articles. At least 39 X, TikTok, and Telegram accounts participated in the operation. Some labelled as parody or fan accounts of famous people, others were real pro-Russian influencers, and anonymous "news" accounts. A portion of the X accounts were amplified inauthentically, with a post being re-shared 80-200 times within the same minute. The Moldovan iteration of the operation was not mainly targeting Moldovan voters, but rather foreign far-right audiences, primarily the Make America Great Again (MAGA) movement, trying to weaken foreign support to Moldova's pro-EU aspirations. The website Eufiles[.]com was the first we identified as being part of the Storm-1516 operation targeting Moldova. The operation published 200 AI-generated articles on Eufiles[.]com, and impersonated real journalists. This was done to make the website appear as a legitimate source. The only non-AI generated article on the site, which also contained a text-to-voice video, was amplified by influencers on X previously known to amplify Storm-1516 content. Storm-1516 is corrosive to the information space in Moldova by methodically weakening trust in democratic institutions and the ruling PAS party. The narratives it builds centre around fabricated corruption scandals, false promises of policy to be introduced in Moldova after the election, and faked evidence of electoral fraud, all of which are aimed at rendering President Maia Sandu illegitimate.

**Systemic Violation Assessment**

- Storm-1516 seeks to interfere in Moldova's democratic electoral process, with the end goal being Russian control over Moldova. The operation tries to undermine trust in Moldova's institutions.
- The manipulation lies both in the content and the tactics used to disseminate it: a. Storm-1516 actively creates and spreads entirely fabricated news stories; b. The operation is manipulative as it is creating impersonation websites and using anonymous accounts to spread the stories, and inauthentically amplifying their content using bots.
- The operation is likely illegal as articles amplified by Storm-1516 often stem from R-FBI, an actor which has already been sanctioned by the EU. The operation may have also committed a number of violations, such as identity theft and election interference

**Narrative**

**Meta-narrative 1:** Sandu and the PAS party are corrupt and need to be removed from power:

Sub-Narrative 1-1: Sandu is making billions on illegal drugs, weapons and human trafficking;  
 Sub-Narrative 1-2: PAS is systematically exploiting minors via its youth structures;  
 Sub-Narrative 1-3: Sandu sent Moldovan criminals to Ukraine to act as executioners for Zelensky;

**Meta-narrative 2:** Western countries and institutions seek to harm Moldova:

Sub-Narrative 2-1: Sandu accepts France's chemical waste and makes Moldova Europe's dumping ground;  
 Sub-Narrative 2-2: The Soros Foundation gave President Sandu €10 million to promote LGBT propaganda in Moldova;

**Meta-narrative 3:** Sandu and PAS are preparing election fraud:

Sub-Narrative 3-1: Moldova is mobilising the police to suppress anticipated mass protests after the election;  
 Sub-Narrative 3-2: PAS manipulates elections by checking ballots in their favour prior to election day.

## Impact

**Reach:** The operation garnered at least 45 million views, but only a few thousand interactions, according to the social media platforms. Attempts at manipulating these numbers have been observed.

**Outcome:** N/A

## Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

**Objective 1:** [T0135.001 Smear](#) - by discrediting Sandu and PAS in the eyes of the Moldovan and international far-right audiences.

**Objective 2:** [T0135.003 Subvert](#) - Moldova's international relations and foreign support by targeting far-right audiences, especially the MAGA movement.

**T0098.001:** [Create Inauthentic News Sites](#) - creating 12 websites, out of which at least 3 mimicked existing media entities and 9 others were to our knowledge completely fabricated.

**T0088.002:** [Deceptively Edit Audio \(Cheap Fakes\)](#) - using text-to-speech (not AI generated) to create "news" segments.

**T0084.002:** [Plagiarise](#) - content from authentic media and rewrite them using AI.

**T0100.003:** [Co-Opted Influencers](#) - The operation seemingly co-opted pro-Russian influencers to spread the content.

## Recommendations and Actions Taken

**Actions Taken:** A detailed report was published that provides an analysis of the operation in Moldova. We also reported some of the key websites involved to their domain provider without any response.

**Recommendations:** The European Commission should impose additional sanctions on entities involved in the operation; The websites and accounts that are part of the operation should also be taken down by the respective platforms.

| Report               | Threat Actor | Evidence             | Authors                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Platforms                        | <a href="#">FIMI Assessment</a> |
|----------------------|--------------|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| <a href="#">Link</a> | Russia.      | <a href="#">Link</a> | Saman Nazari,<br>Alliance4Europe,<br>Eto Buziashvili, DFRLab<br>Victoria Olari, DFRLab<br>Sophie Sacilotto,<br>Debunk.org Ania<br>Logvynova, IPHR<br>(International Partnership<br>for Human Rights)<br>Hannah Schimmele,<br>Polisphere Thomas<br>Smelter, Alliance4Europe<br>Ewan Casandjian,<br>Alliance4Europe Mihaela<br>Tănase (Context.ro)<br>Vasile Popa (Probe Point | Website,<br>TikTok,<br>Telegram. | X,<br><br>High Certainty        |

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